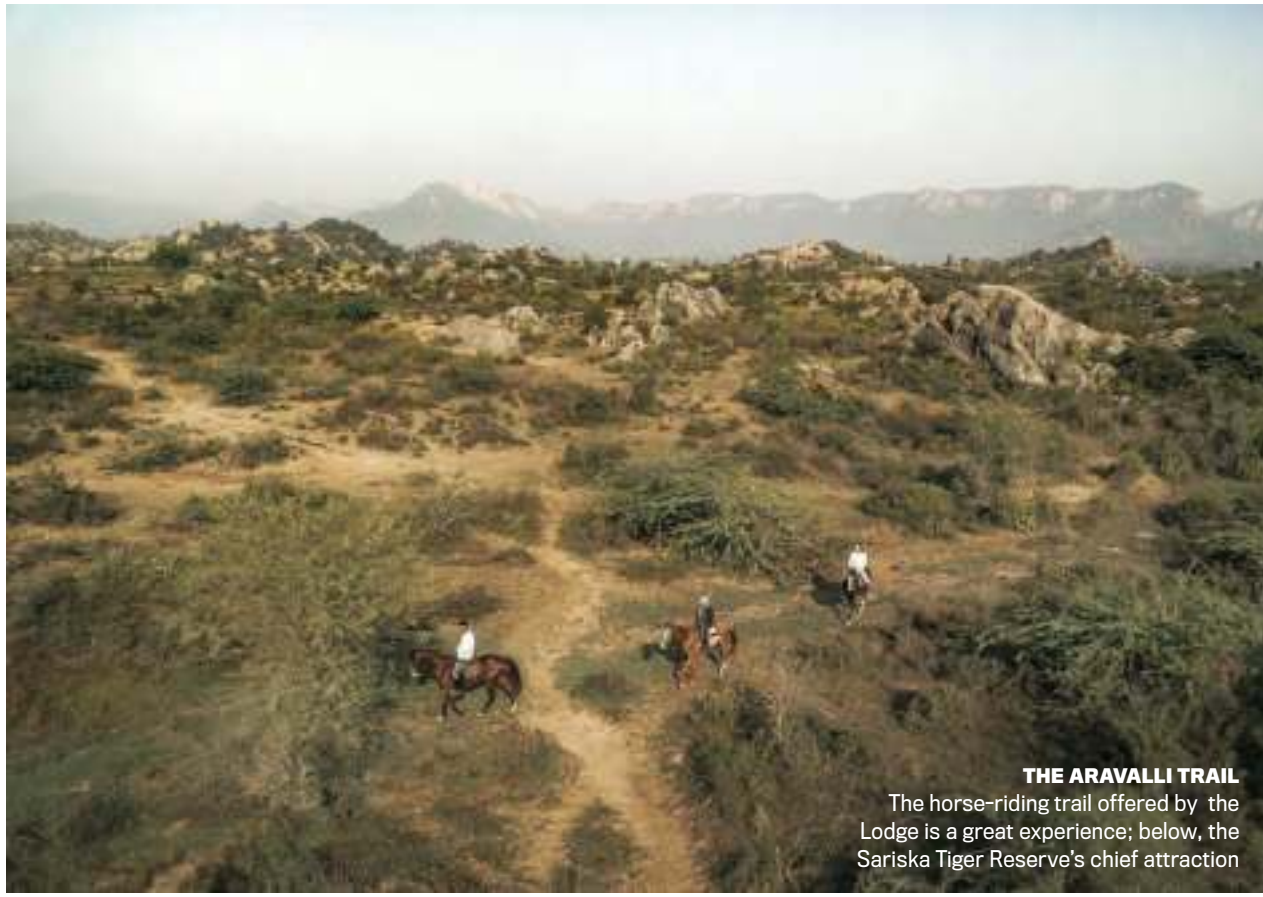


THE ARAVALLI TRAIL
The horse-riding trail offered by the Lodge is a great experience; below, the Sariska Tiger Reserve's chief attraction



each time I spot flame lilies; their crimson and gold flowers look so exotic in this wild terrain. It is almost dusk when we reach the lake. Waves lap gently against the shore as cattle egrets wing past the green hills to their roosts. We alight from the jeep to find out that the Lodge team is waiting for us with masala chai and *garma-garam pakore*, conjured up in the middle of the wilderness. Savouring the contrast between the crisp paneer *pakore* and piquant coriander chutney, the moist breeze from the lake wafting over us, the overcast sky pregnant with rain: the deliciousness of the monsoons comes together all at once.

In semi-arid Rajasthan, there is a special joy to the rains. When we set out the next morning, the whole countryside seems to be smiling. In the fields, bajra stands tall and proud, enclosed by walls of rough-hewn stone. Vines of wild gourds run riot over thorn hedgerows. Buffaloes wallow lazily in muddy ponds. In the courtyard of a village home, a mother bathes her young son, briskly scrubbing him for school. Our jeep leaves the valley for a road into the encircling hills. As it climbs through the forest, I'm in naturalist heaven. The *dhau* trees have put out sage-silver new leaves, each one trembling with tiny drops of water. *Khair, ronjh, kullu, salai*: each tree is budding with new foliage, spreading to embrace the rain.

Plunging through this verdure, we descend into another valley, charmingly secluded, where the bucolic landscape reveals a hidden treasure. Scattered among the bajra fields are the remains of 10th-